

Jesus' Death and Resurrection

A Composite Bible Study: The Chronological Harmony of the Four Gospels

Introduction

The four Gospels do not give us four identical accounts of Jesus' final days. Each writer emphasizes different details and sometimes records events from a different perspective. When those accounts are read together rather than in isolation, however, a remarkably coherent chronology emerges.

The purpose of this study is to place the accounts side by side, address passages that can initially appear difficult to reconcile, and show how the death, burial, resurrection, appearances, and ascension of Jesus fit together within the biblical record.

The purpose is not to force every detail into a rigid timeline when Scripture does not provide one. Where the biblical text leaves the precise sequence uncertain, that uncertainty will be acknowledged. Where the accounts provide enough information to establish a reasonable sequence, the events will be placed accordingly.

One writer may mention one angel while another mentions two. One may identify Mary Magdalene specifically while another speaks of several women. One may record an event in greater detail while another summarizes it. Such differences do not necessarily represent contradictions. Often, they provide complementary perspectives on the same events.

What follows is therefore a chronological harmony based on the testimony of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, with the Gospel accounts read alongside one another.

¹ Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

The Divine Inspiration of Scripture

Before examining the chronological relationship between the four Gospel accounts, it is important to establish the nature of the testimony being considered.

The four Gospels are not merely human attempts to reconstruct the final days of Jesus. Christians believe that Scripture is **God-breathed** and that the Holy Spirit guided the biblical writers in what they recorded.

Paul declares:

“All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for instruction, for conviction, for correction, and for training in righteousness.” — 2 Timothy 3:16

Peter likewise teaches that the writers of Scripture spoke *“from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit”* (2 Peter 1:21).

Divine inspiration does not require the biblical writers to lose their individual personalities, vocabulary, perspectives, or purposes. Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John remain distinct authors, yet their writings are simultaneously the authoritative Word of God.

This distinction is important when approaching the differences among the Gospel accounts. Inspiration does not require four writers to use identical words, record every event in precisely the same sequence, or emphasize the same details. Rather, God spoke through distinct human authors, preserving the truth He intended to communicate while allowing each writer to contribute his own perspective and emphasis.

The four Gospels are therefore both genuinely human accounts and genuinely the inspired Word of God.

This study proceeds from that conviction.

1. Thursday Evening — The Last Supper and Arrest

Preparations for the Passover Meal

Matthew 26:17–19; Mark 14:12–16; Luke 22:7–13

The disciples ask Jesus where they should prepare the Passover meal. Jesus sends Peter and John into Jerusalem with instructions that lead them to an upper room. The preparations are completed, and the disciples gather with Jesus that evening.

The Last Supper

Matthew 26:20–30; Mark 14:17–26; Luke 22:14–38; John 13–17

Jesus washes the disciples' feet, identifies Judas as His betrayer, institutes the Lord's Supper, and predicts Peter's denial.

John records Jesus' extended teaching to His disciples, including His promise of the Holy Spirit, His command to love one another, His teaching concerning the vine and the branches, and His prayer for His disciples and future believers. John 17 records what is commonly called the *High Priestly Prayer*.

This is Jesus' final extended teaching of His disciples before His arrest and crucifixion.

2. The Passover Chronology

One of the most significant chronological questions surrounding Jesus' final days concerns the timing of the Passover.

Matthew, Mark, and Luke describe the preparations for the Last Supper using unmistakable Passover terminology. The disciples ask Jesus where they should prepare for the Passover, and the meal itself is presented within that setting (Matthew 26:17–19; Mark 14:12–16; Luke 22:7–13).

John's Gospel, however, contains statements that have led some readers to conclude that Jesus was crucified before the Passover meal was eaten. John records that the Jewish authorities did not enter Pilate's residence because they wished to avoid ceremonial defilement “*so that they could eat the Passover*” (John 18:28). John also refers to the day of Jesus' crucifixion as “*the day of Preparation for the Passover*” (John 19:14).

At first glance, these statements can appear difficult to reconcile with the Synoptic accounts. If Jesus ate the Passover meal with His disciples on Thursday evening, why does John speak of the Jewish leaders still preparing to “*eat the Passover*”?

Several considerations are important.

First, the term *Passover* could be used in a broader sense to include the festival period surrounding Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. The reference in John 18:28, therefore, does not necessarily require the conclusion that the Passover meal itself had not yet occurred. The Jewish leaders may have been referring to their continued participation in the festival meals and observances.

Second, the expression “*day of Preparation*” does not necessarily mean preparation for the Passover meal itself. The term was also used in connection with preparation for the approaching Sabbath. All four Gospels agree that Jesus was buried before the Sabbath began (Matthew 27:62; Mark 15:42; Luke 23:54; John 19:31, 42).

Third, various explanations have been proposed concerning differences in calendrical reckoning and the use of Passover terminology in the first century. While interpreters differ concerning some of these details, the combined Gospel testimony establishes the central sequence of events.

Jesus shared His final meal with His disciples, went to Gethsemane, was arrested, tried, crucified, died, and was buried before the Sabbath. On the first day of the week, His tomb was found empty, and He appeared alive to His followers.

The four Gospels provide complementary testimony which, when read together, presents a unified and compelling account of the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

3. Gethsemane — The Agony in the Garden

Matthew 26:36–46; Mark 14:32–42; Luke 22:39–46; John 18:1

After the meal, Jesus and His disciples go to the Mount of Olives and enter Gethsemane.

Jesus prays in profound anguish:

“Yet not My will, but Yours be done.” — Luke 22:42

Luke records that an angel strengthens Him (Luke 22:43). The disciples repeatedly fall asleep while Jesus prays.

At last, Jesus tells them that the hour has come.

4. The Arrest of Jesus

Matthew 26:47–56; Mark 14:43–50; Luke 22:47–53; John 18:1–11

Judas arrives with a crowd and identifies Jesus with a kiss.

Peter draws a sword and strikes the servant of the high priest, cutting off his ear. John identifies the servant as Malchus (John 18:10). Jesus stops the violence and heals the wounded man (Luke 22:51).

John records that when Jesus identifies Himself, the soldiers draw back and fall to the ground (John 18:6).

Yet Jesus willingly gives Himself into their hands.

The disciples flee, fulfilling Jesus' prediction that they would be scattered.

5. Friday Early Morning — The Jewish Trials

Matthew 26:57–68; Mark 14:53–65; Luke 22:54–71; John 18:12–24

Jesus is taken first to Annas and then to Caiaphas, the high priest.

False witnesses are brought forward. The religious leaders question Jesus concerning His identity and claims. When Jesus makes His identity clear, the high priest accuses Him of blasphemy.

Matthew records:

“He has blasphemed! Why do we need any more witnesses?” — Matthew 26:65

Jesus is condemned by the Jewish leadership.

During these events, Peter denies three times that he knows Jesus. The rooster crows, and Peter remembers Jesus' prediction and weeps bitterly.

6. Peter's Three Denials and the Rooster Crowing

The four Gospels agree that Peter denied Jesus three times, but they describe the rooster's crowing somewhat differently.

Matthew records Jesus saying:

“Truly I tell you, this very night, before the rooster crows, you will deny Me three times.” — Matthew 26:34

Mark records the prediction more specifically:

“Truly I tell you,” Jesus replied, “this very night, before the rooster crows twice, you will deny Me three times.” — Mark 14:30

Luke and John simply state that the rooster would crow, without specifying the number of times (Luke 22:34; John 13:38).

At first glance, this may appear to be a contradiction. But the difference is readily explained if Mark is providing a more precise detail rather than contradicting the other accounts. Jesus warned Peter that **before the rooster crowed twice**, he would deny Him three times. Matthew, Luke, and John simply refer to the crowing of the rooster as the point marking the end of Peter's denials.

The accounts themselves indicate that Peter first denies knowing Jesus, a second accusation follows, and then a third denial occurs. The rooster crows, and Peter remembers Jesus' prediction and weeps bitterly.

Mark's more detailed wording does not require that the other Gospel writers intended to specify the exact number of times the rooster crowed. Their use of *“before the rooster crows”* can be understood as a general reference to the approaching dawn, while Mark preserves the more precise detail that the rooster crowed twice.

There is therefore no need to conclude that the Gospels disagree about Peter's denials.

The central testimony is consistent:

Peter denied Jesus three times, just as Jesus predicted, and the rooster's crowing brought Peter to the realization that Jesus' prophecy had been fulfilled.

7. The Trial Before Pilate and Herod

Matthew 27:1–31; Mark 15:1–20; Luke 23:1–25; John 18:28–40; 19:1–16

The Jewish leaders bring Jesus to Pilate and present political charges concerning His kingship.

Luke records that Pilate sends Jesus to Herod Antipas. Herod questions Jesus, mocks Him, dresses Him in an elegant robe, and sends Him back to Pilate.

Pilate repeatedly finds no basis for a charge deserving death.

Nevertheless, the crowd demands crucifixion.

Barabbas is released.

Jesus is scourged, crowned with thorns, mocked, and finally delivered to be crucified.

8. The Crucifixion — Friday Morning to Afternoon

Matthew 27:32–56; Mark 15:21–41; Luke 23:26–49; John 19:17–37

Jesus is crucified at Golgotha, “*The Place of the Skull.*”

Two criminals are crucified with Him. A sign identifies Him as Jesus of Nazareth, King of the Jews. Soldiers cast lots for His garments, while bystanders and religious leaders mock Him.

One criminal recognizes Jesus' innocence and asks to be remembered when Jesus comes into His kingdom.

Jesus answers:

“Truly I tell you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.” — Luke 23:43

John records Jesus entrusting His mother to the disciple whom He loved.

Darkness covers the land.

Jesus cries:

“My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?” — Matthew 27:46

He says:

“I am thirsty.” — John 19:28

Then Jesus declares:

“It is finished.” — John 19:30

These words are not the cry of defeat but the declaration that the work He came to accomplish has been completed.

Finally:

“Father, into Your hands I commit My spirit.” — Luke 23:46

Jesus dies.

The Crucifixion in Sequence

Time	Event
About 9:00 AM	Jesus is crucified at Golgotha. Two criminals are crucified with Him.
Morning	Soldiers cast lots for His garments. The inscription identifying Jesus as King of the Jews is displayed.
Morning	One criminal turns to Jesus in faith, and Jesus promises him Paradise.
Noon–3:00 PM	Darkness covers the land. Jesus speaks His final words from the cross.
About 3:00 PM	Jesus declares, <i>“It is finished,”</i> and commits His spirit to the Father.
Immediately afterward	The temple veil is torn, an earthquake occurs, and the Roman centurion declares, <i>“Truly this was the Son of God!”</i>

Matthew 27:51; Mark 15:38–39; Luke 23:45–46; John 19:30–34

Each Gospel emphasizes different details while collectively presenting the same crucifixion.

9. The Burial of Jesus — Friday Afternoon

Matthew 27:57–61; Mark 15:42–47; Luke 23:50–56; John 19:38–42

Because the Sabbath was approaching, Jesus' body was buried quickly.

Joseph of Arimathea asks Pilate for Jesus' body. John also identifies Nicodemus as assisting with the burial.

They wrap Jesus' body in linen with spices and place Him in a new tomb in a garden near the place of crucifixion.

The women observe where He is laid.

A large stone is rolled against the entrance.

Matthew records that the chief priests and Pharisees ask Pilate to secure the tomb because they remember Jesus' prediction that He would rise again. A guard is assigned, and the tomb is sealed (Matthew 27:62–66).

10. Saturday — The Tomb Is Guarded

Matthew 27:62–66

Saturday is the Sabbath.

The disciples are in sorrow and fear.

The tomb remains sealed and guarded.

The Gospel accounts do not portray the disciples as men confidently expecting to see Jesus rise that morning. Their actions demonstrate that they did not yet understand His predictions concerning the resurrection.

The decisive event comes the following morning.

11. Sunday Morning — The Resurrection

Matthew 28:1–10; Mark 16:1–8; Luke 24:1–12; John 20:1–18

All four Gospels agree on the essential fact:

Jesus' tomb was empty on the first day of the week.

The women come to the tomb early in the morning.

Matthew mentions Mary Magdalene and the other Mary.

Mark names Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome.

Luke mentions Mary Magdalene, Joanna, Mary the mother of James, and other women.

John focuses particularly on Mary Magdalene.

The stone has been rolled away, the tomb is empty, and heavenly messengers announce that Jesus has risen.

Matthew records:

“He is not here; He has risen, just as He said!” — Matthew 28:6

The women are instructed to tell the disciples.

12. The Angels at the Tomb

Matthew 28:2–7; Mark 16:5–7; Luke 24:2–7; John 20:11–13

The Gospel accounts mention the heavenly messengers differently.

Matthew refers to “*an angel of the Lord.*”

Mark describes “*a young man dressed in a white robe.*”

Luke describes two men in radiant apparel.

John describes two angels in white.

These descriptions do not require contradictory events. If two messengers were present, one writer could focus on the one who spoke while another could mention both.

The principle is simple:

Mentioning one person does not necessarily mean that no one else was present.

Each Gospel writer emphasizes details relevant to his account.

13. Mary Magdalene and the Empty Tomb

John 20:1–18; Mark 16:9–11

John gives particular attention to Mary Magdalene.

After seeing that the stone has been removed, she runs to tell Peter and John:

“They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we do not know where they have put Him!” —
John 20:2

Peter and John run to the tomb.

Peter enters. The linen cloths are lying there, with the cloth that had been around Jesus' head lying separately.

John enters, sees, and believes.

The disciples return home, but Mary remains outside weeping.

She looks inside and sees two angels.

Then she turns and sees Jesus, though she does not initially recognize Him.

Jesus says:

“Mary.”

She recognizes Him and responds:

“Rabboni!”

This is why John's account focuses so strongly on Mary's personal encounter with the risen Christ.

A precise reconstruction of every movement of the women is not given, so the sequence should not be stated more dogmatically than Scripture allows.

14. Jesus Appears to the Other Women

Matthew 28:9–10

Matthew records another resurrection-morning appearance.

As the women are going to tell the disciples, Jesus meets them and says:

“Greetings!” — Matthew 28:9

They embrace His feet and worship Him.

Jesus tells them not to be afraid and instructs them to tell His brothers to go to Galilee.

The accounts therefore record more than one resurrection-morning encounter.

15. The Guards Report the Empty Tomb

Matthew 28:11–15

The guards report what happened to the chief priests.

The religious leaders give the soldiers money and instruct them to say:

“His disciples came by night and stole Him away while we were asleep.” — Matthew 28:13

Matthew records that this explanation continued to circulate.

The tomb had been secured, yet an explanation was required for its emptiness.

16. The Road to Emmaus

Luke 24:13–35; Mark 16:12–13

Later that day, two disciples are walking toward Emmaus.

Jesus joins them, but they do not recognize Him.

He explains the Scriptures concerning Himself:

“And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, He explained to them what was written about Himself in all the Scriptures.” — Luke 24:27

When they reach Emmaus, Jesus breaks bread with them.

Their eyes are opened, they recognize Him, and He disappears from their sight.

They immediately return to Jerusalem to tell the others.

17. Jesus Appears to the Disciples — Thomas Absent

Luke 24:36–49; John 20:19–23

That same evening, Jesus appears to the disciples behind locked doors.

He says:

“Peace be with you.” — John 20:19

The disciples are initially frightened.

Jesus shows them His hands and His side. Luke records that He invites them to examine Him physically and eats in their presence.

He then explains how His suffering, death, and resurrection fulfilled Scripture.

John records:

“Receive the Holy Spirit.” — John 20:22

Thomas is not present.

18. The Following Week — Jesus Appears to Thomas

John 20:24–29

Eight days later, the disciples are again gathered behind locked doors.

This time Thomas is present.

Jesus invites him to examine the evidence.

Thomas responds:

“My Lord and my God!” — John 20:28

Jesus then says:

“Because you have seen Me, you have believed; blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.” — John 20:29

Thomas had demanded evidence, and Jesus provided it. Jesus also pointed beyond Thomas to those who would believe through the testimony of His witnesses.

19. Further Appearance — The Sea of Galilee

John 21

Jesus later appears to His disciples beside the Sea of Galilee.

Several disciples have returned to fishing. After a night without a catch, Jesus directs them to cast the net on the right side of the boat.

They catch 153 fish.

Jesus prepares breakfast for them.

After the meal, Jesus restores Peter. Three times He asks Peter whether he loves Him, and three times Peter responds.

The man who had denied Jesus three times is given an opportunity to affirm his love three times.

20. Jesus Appears to Many Witnesses

The resurrection appearances were not limited to those recorded in the four Gospels.

Paul summarizes the apostolic testimony:

“For what I received I passed on to you as of first importance: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that He was buried, that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and that He appeared to Cephas and then to the Twelve.” — 1 Corinthians 15:3–5

Paul continues by saying that Jesus appeared to more than five hundred brothers at one time, then to James, then to all the apostles, and finally to Paul himself (1 Corinthians 15:6–8).

The Gospels therefore record selected appearances rather than every appearance of the risen Christ.

21. The Great Commission

Matthew 28:16–20; Mark 16:14–18

The disciples meet Jesus in Galilee as He had instructed.

Jesus gives them the Great Commission:

“Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.” — Matthew 28:19

He commands them to teach the nations to obey everything He has commanded.

The disciples are commissioned to proclaim what they have witnessed.

22. Forty Days Between Resurrection and Ascension

Acts 1:1–12

Luke provides an essential chronological key:

“After His suffering, He presented Himself to them with many convincing proofs that He was alive. He appeared to them over a span of forty days and spoke about the kingdom of God.” — Acts 1:3

The resurrection appearances therefore cannot all be compressed into resurrection Sunday.

Jesus continued to appear to His followers and teach them during the forty days between His resurrection and ascension.

23. The Ascension

Luke 24:50–53; Acts 1:9–12

At the conclusion of those forty days, Jesus leads His disciples to the vicinity of Bethany and the Mount of Olives.

He blesses them and is taken up into heaven.

Two angels tell the disciples:

“Men of Galilee, why do you stand here looking into the sky? This same Jesus, who has been taken from you into heaven, will come back in the same way you have seen Him go into heaven.”
— Acts 1:11

The resurrection story therefore culminates not merely in an empty tomb but in the ascension of Christ and the promise of His return.

24. The Chronological Harmony

The essential sequence can be summarized as follows:

Day / Time	Event
Thursday evening	Passover meal / Last Supper
Thursday night	Gethsemane and arrest
Friday early morning	Jewish trials
Friday morning	Pilate, Herod, and final condemnation
Friday about 9 AM	Crucifixion
Friday noon–3 PM	Darkness and final words
Friday about 3 PM	Jesus dies
Friday late afternoon	Burial in Joseph's tomb
Saturday	Sabbath; tomb sealed and guarded
Sunday early morning	Women discover the empty tomb
Sunday morning	Jesus appears to Mary Magdalene and the other women
Sunday afternoon	Road to Emmaus
Sunday evening	Jesus appears to the disciples; Thomas absent
Following week	Jesus appears to Thomas
Following weeks	Additional appearances, including Galilee
Forty days after resurrection	Ascension

This table presents the broad sequence. Scripture does not provide an exact hour or day for every resurrection appearance.

25. The Nature of Eyewitness Testimony

Consider a modern example. Suppose a shooting occurs at a gas station. Four people witness the event from different positions. When detectives interview them, they may describe the same event differently.

One witness may remember the color of the vehicle. Another may focus on the shooter's clothing. A third may remember the victim's words. A fourth may describe what happened immediately afterward.

Their accounts would not be expected to use identical words or contain exactly the same details. Investigators would compare the statements, identify the points on which the witnesses agree, account for differences in perspective, and reconstruct the most complete picture of what occurred.

When the case came to trial, the testimony and evidence of all four witnesses would be presented to the jury. The individual accounts would then be considered together rather than in isolation. Properly harmonized, those accounts would provide a fuller and more complete picture of the event than any single witness could provide alone. **The composite picture portrays the fullest truth of what actually occurred.**

The comparison is helpful when considering the Gospel accounts.

The Gospel writers are reporting not merely a few minutes of activity, but a remarkable series of events extending from the Last Supper through Jesus' arrest, trials, crucifixion, death, burial, resurrection, and subsequent appearances.

Matthew and John were eyewitnesses of much of Jesus' ministry and His final days. Mark and Luke wrote from the testimony of those who had witnessed these events. Early church testimony strongly associates Mark's Gospel with the preaching and testimony of Peter. Luke specifically explains that he investigated the accounts handed down by *“those who from the beginning were eyewitnesses and servants of the word”* (Luke 1:2).

The events recorded in the final chapters of the Gospels unfolded over several days and involved numerous locations, individuals, conversations, and appearances. The four Gospel accounts were also written over a period of years rather than as four simultaneous reports produced immediately after the events. Yet each writer preserves a testimony that fits within the larger historical record. It should therefore not be surprising that the writers emphasize different details, record different conversations, and sometimes focus on different individuals.

The result is not four identical narratives, but four complementary accounts that, when considered together, converge to give us the fullest composite picture of the same central events.

26. “Three Days and Three Nights”

One of the most common objections to the traditional Friday crucifixion and Sunday resurrection concerns Jesus' statement:

“For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.” — Matthew 12:40

At first reading, this can sound like a precise statement of seventy-two hours. If Jesus meant three complete twenty-four-hour periods, the traditional Friday-afternoon crucifixion and Sunday-morning resurrection would appear difficult to reconcile with His words.

We should therefore take the statement seriously and ask how His Jewish audience would have understood the expression.

A Biblical Pattern for Counting Days

Esther instructed the Jews:

“Go and gather together all the Jews in Susa and fast for me. Do not eat or drink for three days, night or day. I and my maidens will fast as you do.” — Esther 4:16

Yet the next chapter says:

“On the third day, Esther put on her royal attire and stood in the inner court of the palace.” — Esther 5:1

Esther speaks of *“three days, night or day,”* yet acts **on the third day**, not after three completed twenty-four-hour periods.

This provides a biblical example of inclusive reckoning, in which portions of days are included within the numbered period.

“Raised on the Third Day”

Jesus repeatedly predicted that He would be killed and raised **on the third day**:

“From that time on Jesus began to explain to His disciples that He must go to Jerusalem and suffer many things at the hands of the elders, chief priests, and scribes, and that He must be killed and raised to life on the third day.” — Matthew 16:21

He repeated this prediction in Matthew 17:23 and Matthew 20:19.

Paul summarizes the apostolic gospel:

“For what I received I passed on to you as of first importance: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that He was buried, that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures.” — 1 Corinthians 15:3–4

Thus, *“three days and three nights”* in Matthew 12:40 must be understood alongside Jesus' repeated statement that He would rise **on the third day**.

How the Friday-to-Sunday Chronology Works

Under the biblical pattern of inclusive reckoning:

Period

Event

Friday — Day 1	Jesus is crucified, dies in the afternoon, and is placed in the tomb before sunset.
Friday night	Jesus' body remains in the tomb.
Saturday — Day 2	Jesus' body remains in the tomb throughout the Sabbath.
Saturday night	Jesus remains in the tomb.
Sunday — Day 3	Jesus rises from the dead before the women discover the empty tomb.

The period therefore extends across **three numbered days—Friday, Saturday, and Sunday**. It includes the nights following Friday and Saturday, while portions of the first and third days are included in the reckoning.

The expression does not require us to claim that Jesus was in the tomb for three complete twenty-four-hour periods.

Matthew's reference to Jonah also reinforces the prophetic nature of the statement. Jonah was in the great fish “*three days and three nights*” (Jonah 1:17), and Jesus uses Jonah as a sign pointing to His own death, burial, and resurrection.

The biblical manner of reckoning time allows the Friday-to-Sunday chronology to stand alongside Jesus' repeated and unmistakable declaration that He would be raised **on the third day**.

Jesus truly died. Jesus truly entered the tomb. He remained there through the Sabbath. And He truly rose from the dead on the third day.

27. Why the Gospel Accounts Can Be Harmonized

The differences among the Gospel accounts become easier to understand when we recognize that the writers were not attempting to provide four identical transcripts.

Consider some of the examples examined in this study.

Matthew mentions “*an angel of the Lord*” at the tomb, while Luke describes two men in radiant apparel. Mark describes a young man dressed in a white robe, and John records two angels. These descriptions need not conflict. If two heavenly messengers were present, one writer could focus on the one who spoke while another could mention both. It is also possible that the writers are describing different moments in the events surrounding the discovery of the empty tomb.

The same principle applies to the women who came to the tomb. Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John identify different women by name, but none requires the conclusion that the women mentioned by another Gospel were absent. The accounts may emphasize different individuals within the same group or describe different movements and moments during that extraordinary morning.

Peter's denials provide another example. All four Gospels agree that Peter denied Jesus three times. Mark preserves the additional detail that the rooster would crow twice, while Matthew, Luke, and John simply mention the rooster's crowing. The difference in detail does not alter the central event or create a contradiction.

The resurrection appearances likewise unfolded over a period of time rather than occurring in one single encounter. One Gospel may record an appearance that another does not mention. Two accounts may describe the same appearance while emphasizing different details, or they may record separate appearances occurring at different times. Luke's statement that Jesus appeared to His followers over forty days makes clear that the Gospel writers were selecting from a larger body of events rather than attempting to record every appearance.

These examples illustrate an important principle:

Different details do not necessarily mean contradiction. Sometimes different writers describe the same event from different perspectives. At other times, they may be recording different events or appearances within a larger sequence.

When the four accounts are read together, they present a coherent sequence:

Jesus died. He was buried. The tomb was found empty. Jesus appeared alive to His followers. He continued to teach them for forty days. He ascended into heaven. And He promised to return.

The purpose of harmonization is therefore not to make the four Gospels say exactly the same thing or to force every difference into a single event. It is to recognize how their distinct accounts fit together while preserving the particular testimony and emphasis of each writer.

The differences do not diminish the authority of Scripture. They demonstrate how God used distinct human authors to provide complementary accounts of the same historical reality while preserving the truth He intended to communicate.

28. From Fearful Disciples to Bold Witnesses

One of the most striking pieces of evidence surrounding the resurrection is the dramatic transformation of the apostles.

Before Jesus' resurrection, the disciples were frightened and discouraged. When Jesus was arrested, "*all the disciples deserted Him and fled*" (Matthew 26:56). Peter denied three times that he knew Jesus (Matthew 26:69–75). After the crucifixion, the disciples gathered behind locked doors "*for fear of the Jews*" (John 20:19).

Then they encountered the risen Christ.

The men who had fled from Jesus' arrest soon stood publicly in Jerusalem proclaiming that God had raised Him from the dead.

Peter declared:

“The God of our fathers raised up Jesus, whom you killed by hanging Him on a tree.” — Acts 5:30

When ordered to stop preaching in Jesus' name, the apostles answered:

“We cannot stop speaking about what we have seen and heard.” — Acts 4:20

When they were beaten for preaching Christ, they left *“rejoicing that they had been counted worthy of suffering disgrace for the Name.” — Acts 5:41*

Peter proclaimed:

“God has raised this Jesus to life, to which we are all witnesses.” — Acts 2:32

The significance of the apostles' transformation should not be overstated. Scripture does not provide the details of every apostle's death. The New Testament does, however, clearly establish that these men moved from fear and flight to bold public proclamation despite imprisonment, beating, threats, and persecution.

Early church tradition holds that all of the apostles except John ultimately died as martyrs for their faith. While the historical evidence for the individual deaths varies, this tradition has been remarkably persistent throughout Christian history.

What we do know with certainty is this: **the men who had fled when Jesus was arrested became men who publicly proclaimed His resurrection despite knowing that their testimony could cost them their lives.**

Something happened between the frightened disciples of Friday and the bold witnesses of Acts.

The Gospels and Acts identify that something:

They encountered the risen Christ.

Conclusion

The death and resurrection of Jesus Christ stand at the center of the Christian faith.

The four Gospels present the events from different perspectives, yet when those perspectives are read together, they form a remarkably coherent account.

Jesus celebrated the final meal with His disciples. He went to Gethsemane. He was betrayed and arrested. He was tried by the Jewish authorities and condemned by Pilate. He was crucified and died. He was buried in a guarded tomb.

On the first day of the week, the tomb was found empty.

Jesus appeared alive to His followers and to many other witnesses. He continued to teach them for forty days. Then He ascended into heaven.

The significance of the resurrection is not merely that Jesus' teachings survived His death. The New Testament presents the resurrection as a physical event witnessed by His followers. They saw Him, touched Him, spoke with Him, ate with Him, saw His wounds, and watched Him ascend.

The transformation of those disciples—from frightened men who fled at His arrest into bold witnesses who endured persecution—stands as powerful testimony to the certainty with which they proclaimed that they had encountered the risen Christ.

The final testimony of the New Testament is therefore not merely that Jesus *lived*.

It is that **Jesus died, Jesus was buried, Jesus rose again, Jesus appeared to His followers, Jesus ascended to the Father, and Jesus will come again.**

The angel's words remain the fitting conclusion:

“This same Jesus... will come back.” — Acts 1:11

The One who died is alive.

The One who rose has ascended.

And the One who ascended is coming again.

Maranatha!